

Past \$10k: what changes

Week 10, Lecture 2 · B2C to \$10k MRR

Autumn 2026 · A 10-Week Growth Manual for Technical Founders

What we'll cover

- The shape of the growth curve from \$10k to \$100k MRR
- What you need to hire vs what AI can absorb
- When to take money vs stay bootstrapped
- The graduate-to-compound mindset: lifecycle, SEO, brand
- How to think about your first 30 days after the course ends
- Send-off: the course ends; the rhythm doesn't

The shape of the next stretch

\$10k to \$30k MRR: the second growth stage

The biggest myth about \$10k MRR: that it implies a path to \$30k.

It doesn't. \$10k MRR means one of two things:

1. You found a wedge channel that works and the product retains. The path to \$30k is repeating what works while finding a second engine.
2. You found a niche audience that is now saturated. The path to \$30k requires a new channel or a broader audience definition.

The diagnostic quadrant from lecture 1 tells you which situation you are in.

The three inflection points

Each milestone changes what the business is:

- **\$10k MRR:** the product is real, the channel exists. The constraint is usually acquisition volume or channel saturation.
- **\$30k MRR:** the first hire is plausible. The constraint is usually time: there is more to do than one person can execute.
- **\$100k MRR:** the business requires systems, not heroics. Growth becomes a function, not a personal output.

Most solo founders plateau at \$10k because \$10k to \$30k requires doing things that feel like "not my job."

(Rachitsky, 2022)

The Racecar framework at \$10k+

At \$10k MRR, most solo founders have:

- One working **growth engine** (the wedge channel)
- One weak **lubricant** (something that improves activation or retention)
- No **turbo boosts** (no PR moments, no partnerships)

The missing pieces that unlock \$30k:

- A second engine (usually a different content type, a referral loop, or a second platform)
- A lifecycle sequence (email or in-app) that lifts D30 retention by 5-10 percentage points

(Rachitsky, 2022)

Hire vs AI vs keep solo

The new solo leverage calculus

In 2026, the question is not "can I afford to hire?" but "what requires a human?"

Things AI handles at B2C scale today:

- First-pass copywriting for lifecycle messages and ads
- Image and video asset generation for creative testing
- Customer support triage and FAQ responses
- Code for instrumenting events, building dashboards, shipping feature flags

Things that still require a human:

- Judgment on what to build next
- Relationships with distribution partners
- Editorial voice and brand distinctiveness

When you actually need to hire

The signal is not MRR. The signal is time budget.

Hire when a task is:

1. Recurring (takes the same 2+ hours every week)
2. Not the founder's highest-leverage work
3. Teachable (a reasonable person can do it with a week of onboarding)

At \$10k MRR bootstrapped, the first hire is usually support or ops, not growth. Growth is still the founder's job until the product retains well enough that channel work compounds.

Bootstrapped vs funded

The bootstrap-or-raise decision

This is a judgment call, not a formula. But the inputs are:

- **Market size:** a \$5M TAM business may never justify VC terms. Bootstrap it.
- **CAC structure:** if your product requires paid acquisition at scale, you need capital before you can grow. Raise.
- **Time horizon:** bootstrapping means slower growth with full ownership. Raising means faster growth with dilution and investor expectations.
- **Your stress tolerance:** both paths are hard. They are hard in different ways.

Pieter Levels bootstrapped Nomad List to \$2M+ ARR. It would have been a bad VC investment and an excellent lifestyle business.

(Levels, 2019)

The honest version of the raise question

Most solo B2C founders raise too early, for the wrong reason: the product isn't growing and they think capital will fix it.

Capital doesn't fix a leak. It fills the bucket faster while it drains.

Raise when:

- The product retains (D30 above 20% at minimum)
- You have a proven channel (CAC below LTV/3)
- The constraint is volume, not product or channel fit

Raising before those conditions means paying a high price (dilution, board seats, pressure) to learn lessons you should learn on your own runway.

The graduate-to-compound mindset

What "compound" means in B2C

The growth tactics from weeks 1-9 were mostly linear: one output produces one unit of reach. Compound tactics produce outputs that generate their own outputs:

- **Lifecycle messages** that activate dormant users and improve D30 retention permanently
- **Programmatic SEO** pages that accumulate ranking over months
- **Brand:** the reputation that makes future channel output more effective per unit

"Compound" doesn't mean passive. It means the work you do in month 3 is still working in month 9.

(Rachitsky, 2022; Levels, 2019)

The first compound move available to you

From Brian Balfour: "Retention is the center of the growth engine. Everything else is just the size and speed of the flywheel."

The highest-ROI compound move for most B2C founders at \$10k MRR:

1. Build a 5-email lifecycle sequence triggered by the activation event
2. Each email has one job: move the user to the next natural usage moment
3. Track D30 retention for the cohort that received the sequence vs. the cohort that didn't

If the sequence lifts D30 by 5 percentage points, LTV increases, CAC ceiling rises, and every channel becomes more efficient.

(Balfour, 2023)

The graduate-to-compound checklist

Before the course ends, answer:

- ☐ Do you have a lifecycle sequence with at least 3 emails that are triggered, not scheduled?
- ☐ Do you have one SEO page that is indexed and could compound in search?
- ☐ Do you have a brand asset (a format, a voice, a recurring content type) that makes future output recognizable?
- ☐ Is your public output from weeks 6-10 on a single channel, compounding, or scattered?

One yes is enough to start. Compound moves take 90 days to show signal. Start one this week.

"Retention is widely considered to be the most important metric, yet it remains poorly understood."

Lenny Rachitsky (2020)

What is good retention? (Lenny's Newsletter)

Take-aways

1. \$10k to \$30k MRR requires a second growth engine or a broadened audience, not just more output on the existing channel.
2. Hire when a task is recurring, teachable, and below your highest-leverage work. AI has raised the threshold for when hiring makes sense.
3. Raise when the product retains, the channel is proven, and the constraint is volume. Not before.
4. The graduate-to-compound mindset means starting one 90-day compound move before the course ends.
5. The course ends Friday. The rhythm doesn't.

What's next

- **Section (Friday):** Stall diagnosis clinic. Capstone defense. 15 minutes per student.
- **Reading:** "Week 10 synthesis" at </c/b2c-10k-mrr-26au/readings/wk10> (the longest reading of the course)
- **After Friday:** The path-to-\$10k-MRR plan you defended is your week 1 post-course agenda. Monday is not a break; it is the first week of the intervention.